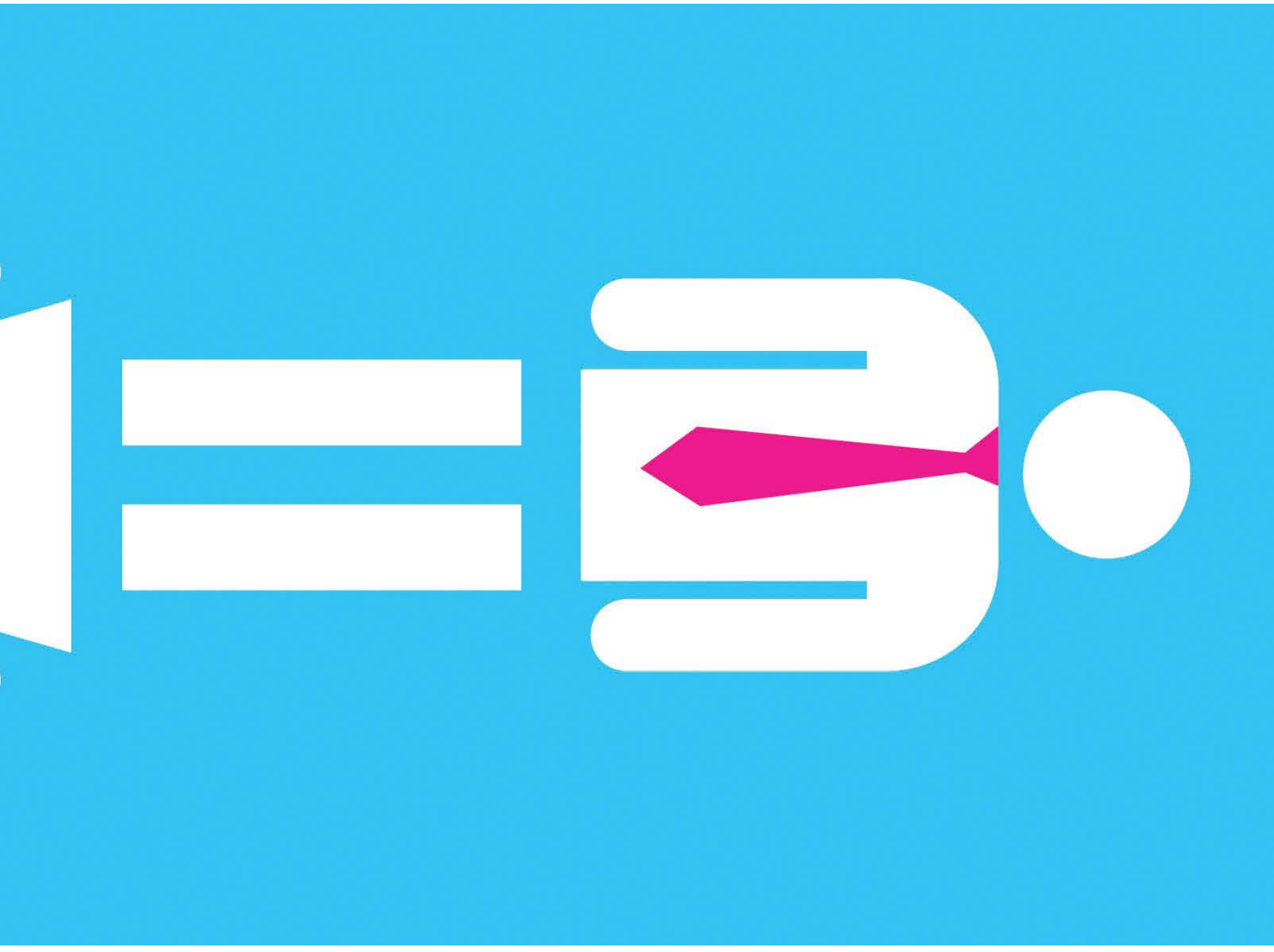


Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

could pose big barriers. However, that picture is changing too. The lack of paid work opportunities in rural India has made families more accepting of their daughters looking for work in the cities. But cities are inhospitable, expensive and difficult to negotiate in terms of housing and support networks.

Heading into 2025, what can be done to alter the status quo? Here are four actionable suggestions.

One, women's educational attainment has increased rapidly over the past two decades, but the FLFPR has a U-shape with education: those with the lowest and highest levels of education participate the most in the labour force. We need to create job opportunities for all women, with particular attention to those with middle level of education. Employers should be open to employing these women at petrol pumps, as taxi and bus drivers, in the tourism industry, as delivery agents, in the hospitality and healthcare industries, and even as mechanics.

Two, for those willing to migrate to cities, we need to create affordable low-cost housing, hostels for single working women, and fast and efficient public transportation.

Three, for rural and urban women, provision of piped water and gas connections at home should be a top priority. These drastically reduce the time spent on meal preparation. Piped gas additionally reduces indoor air pollution and has substantial health benefits.

Four, we need to invest in the care economy by setting up or strengthening/enhancing child- and eldercare facilities in rural and urban areas. These facilities need to be affordable, accessible and safe, which might require the partnership of both public and private sectors. This provision is essential to reduce and redistribute the care burden, with the added benefit that it creates jobs that are both local and green.

International experience has demonstrated that women's economic independence drives the last nail in the coffin of a sticky social norm: the preference for a son, or the desire to have at least one son, as families realise that daughters can provide old-age support too. As we enter 2025, we need all hands on deck to create an environment where women can thrive in paid work. This is the key to unlocking their potential and driving lasting social and economic change. ■

Ashwini Deshpande *is professor of Economics & academic director, Centre for Economic Data and Analysis (CEDA), Ashoka University. Views are personal*